I was finally given the microphone at the end of the presentation, but before I could speak the crowd started chanting ‘Sachinnn Sachinnn’ and they just would not stop. As I have said many times before, these chants will reverberate in my ears for as long as I live. I asked the crowd to calm down and not make me more emotional than I already was. I had also brought a bottle of water in case I was choked with emotion in the middle of it all.

I took from my pocket the list of people I wanted to thank that I had written on the plane back from Kolkata after the first Test match. The challenge now was to say different things about each one. They all meant the world to me and I wanted to thank them individually for their contribution. Somehow, the words just came to me. I spoke my heart out.

When they showed my team-mates Sourav, Rahul and Laxman on the big screen I spoke about them. When I was speaking about my wife I could see her break down in front of me and Sara trying to console her. Arjun also comforted his mother as I went on to thank the best partner I have ever had. I can never say enough about her.

I thanked my fans and the supporters of Indian cricket, who have always stood by me. It did not matter to them if I scored a zero or a hundred. They were always there with me and their support has been my biggest source of strength.

It is pertinent to recount here an incident I will remember forever, one that demonstrates what my fans mean to me. I was once in Chennai when I had the opportunity to meet a number of special children. Their teacher pointed to one child in a wheelchair and said that he was my biggest fan and his ultimate ambition was to hold my bat. I put my arm around him and told him, ‘Okay, done. Let’s play cricket together.’ Immediately, I sent someone to fetch my bat and a couple of tennis balls from the dressing room. To my complete amazement and absolute utter delight, the boy stood up and played three balls on his own. For him to be able to do so was incredible. We all gave him an ovation and I have often spoken about this child, who left a lasting impression.

After a while I told the crowd I’d finish soon, only for them to scream ‘Noooooooooo!’ It seemed they wanted me to carry on. In the end I spoke for twenty minutes, the longest I have ever spoken at a stretch in my life. I genuinely do not know how I did so at such a difficult time; it was as if someone from above had blessed me. Other than that, I can’t explain how I managed to navigate the speech without a hiccup.